If chervil isn't available, you can replace it with a few leaves of fresh mint to finish. You can also use frozen peas if fresh peas are out of season.

potage saint germain

SERVES 4 **PREP** 15 MINS **COOK** 1 HR **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS
BEFORE MADEIRA IS ADDED

1 tbsp sunflower, peanut, or mild-flavored olive oil
1 tbsp butter plus 2 tbsp chilled butter, diced
4 large scallions (white parts only), chopped
1½ quarts (1½ liters) hot chicken or vegetable stock
5½oz (150g) split green peas, rinsed and drained
sea salt and freshly ground black pepper
1lb 2oz (500g) fresh green peas (about 1¾lb/800g unshelled)
1 small head soft lettuce, leaves snipped
1 large egg yolk
3 tbsp crème fraîche
1–2 tbsp Madeira or port
few sprigs of chervil

1 Put a large sauté pan over medium heat. Add the oil and 1 tbsp butter, then stir in the scallions. Reduce the heat a little and cook for 5 minutes, stirring frequently. Pour the hot stock into the pan, and then add the split peas. Season lightly with salt and pepper, and bring back to a simmer. Reduce the heat, cover, and cook for another 20 minutes, stirring occasionally.

2 Add the garden peas and the lettuce, stir, and cook for 5 minutes. Let cool a little, then pour the contents of the pan into a blender or food processor and process until smooth. Push the soup back into the pan through a fine sieve, mashing the vegetables with the back of a spoon to extract as much as possible. Pour ½ cup water through the sieve to thin down the soup. Reheat gently over low heat.

3 In a cup or small bowl combine the egg yolk and the crème fraîche with 2–3 tablespoons of the hot soup. Whisk this into the pan a little at a time. Continue cooking until the soup is piping hot. Adjust the seasoning. Just before serving, stir in the Madeira or port. Whisk in the diced butter and sprinkle a little snipped chervil over the top.